WrestleCraft: Be The Booker. Game Review and Long-Term Roadmap

23 October 2026 · Ryan

1. Executive summary and current score

Current score: 6.5 / 10, with the best slope in its genre. WrestleCraft already has the deepest booking simulation on the market and a presentation idea nobody else has. It is not yet a game a stranger can pick up and love: the week has no single headline, presses and slams lack weight, and a new player drowns in vocabulary. Every one of those gaps is the kind that time, focus and taste close, and this project has all three: one owner with no deadline, Opus 5.5 as the builder, and freedom to change the engine, the rules or anything else.

How this review reads the project. WrestleCraft is a one-person game. Ryan directs, decides, plays and judges; Opus 5.5 writes the plans, the code, the tests and the assets, using any GitHub tool, Claude plugin, mod or other tool that helps. The goal is to perfect the game over the long term before showing it to anyone. Every new system this report proposes is a candidate only: under the development protocol (`CLAUDE.md` rule 9d) each needs a standalone blueprint, an answered question vault and Ryan's explicit go-ahead before any source file is made.

The review is built from the repository at version 0.88 (595 commits since 6 October 2026), the plans in `docs/plans/`, the open queue in `TASKS.md`, a 20-week headless run of every company in the parody world, and the earlier full review of 17 October (version 0.85).

Scorecard

Area	Score	In one line
Simulation depth	9.0	Over 40 interlocking systems: living feuds, relationship memory, fog of war, the road, networks, the press, progression.
Technical foundation	8.0	Deterministic seeded engine, plain-JSON saves, 52 headless and 42 browser test suites; long runs end with errs 0 and NaN 0.
Emergent storytelling	7.5	People remember every decision and story sifting finds feuds in history; the Director that would pace it all is only a plan.
Audio	6.5	Picked by ear and tasteful. Boos and the mixed reaction are missing, so heels and tweeners sound like faces.
Presentation and animation	6.0	The papercraft diorama is distinctive; impacts lack weight, the camera clips, and motion does not yet sell scale.
UX and readability	6.0	One-screen pages and pop-up choices are right; consequences are explained after the fact more than previewed before.
Core loop clarity	5.5	Office, Book and Show hand tension forward, but too many systems speak at once.
Onboarding	4.5	Booking power, action points, heat, freshness and markets arrive with little guided teaching.

Area	Score	In one line
Steam readiness	4.0	Electron wrapper and 62 achievements exist; the Steam calls have never run against the Steam client. Not urgent with no reveal planned.

The weighted result is 6.5. Depth alone would justify an 8; onboarding, feel and the noise of too many systems pull it down. Multiplayer does not exist and is not scored.

Core identity

You are the booker. Every week you build a show out of people, then sit in the gorilla position while it goes out live, making calls you cannot take back. Everything else (the locker room, money, networks, rivals, history) exists to make next week's card a harder and more interesting decision.

Primary genre

A narrative management simulation, in the line of Extreme Warfare and Total Extreme Wrestling, with Football Manager's depth and Crusader Kings' people-first drama. It is not a 4X, but it maps onto one cleanly, which is why the Civilization and Stellaris lessons in section 4 transfer:

4X verb	WrestleCraft equivalent
eXplore	Fog of war on talent: the road agent's reads, scouting the indies, learning pairings by running them.
eXpand	The road and its city markets, new weekly shows, new belts, streaming, bigger buildings.
eXploit	The card itself: turning people, feuds and moments into tickets, ratings and trust.
eXterminate	Ratings wars, head-to-head nights, invasions, raiding a rival's roster.

Unique selling proposition

The only booking sim where the show is a live broadcast you direct. Rivals resolve a card into a results screen. WrestleCraft puts the player in the gorilla position with calls that cannot be skipped, played out in a handmade papercraft diorama, in front of a locker room that remembers every answer. Three pillars no competitor combines: people with memory (`relBump()`, `youRemember()`), fog of war on outcomes (stars only after the bell), and a full creator suite (Create a Wrestler, Create a Move, Create a Scene, Create a Belt, a World Editor).

2. The 10/10 vision: the ultimate evolution

The paradigm shift: stop adding systems and start authoring seasons. Today WrestleCraft is a world you manage; the 10/10 WrestleCraft is a story you write, paced by a director, where every system's only job is to hand the booker one sharp decision at the right moment. The engine is ready for this. The gap is orchestration, legibility and feel, and a long timeline means each can be done properly rather than quickly.

The finished game, described

A player opens a save they started months ago. The desk shows one headline: the champion they built from nothing wants out, and the network renewal is three weeks away. The run sheet lights up in pencil as they drag a segment: this pairing cools the crowd, that one is a hot follow-up. On the air, a near fall lands with a held frame, a creased paper figure, a camera push and a crowd that counts along. The night ends on a new problem. At the flagship the year is judged, stamped and filed in a Timeline of stills they made themselves. They have shared their world on the Workshop, and their e-fed league of eight friends books the next week tonight.

The four moves that close the gap

1. **One spine: the Director runs the week.** The planned Director (`TASKS.md` 0aa) becomes the single gate every event, call and matter passes through, in the manner of RimWorld's storyteller. It reads tension, picks a fire, a chance or colour, and caps interruptions. Forty systems stop competing for the desk; the player meets one headline, two supporting threads and quiet everywhere else.
2. **A promise ledger as the core loop.** Every booking choice opens a visible thread (a challenge issued, a debt owed, a title promised, a story ripening), and every thread has a payoff window. The card becomes the act of paying promises off at the right time: the Civilization Eureka principle applied to stories.
3. **Three clocks, each with a ceremony.** The week (the card and its stamped grade), the month (the big event and the magazine), the era (a year judged at the flagship). "One more turn" lives in the overlap: one clock is always about to ring.
4. **Preview before consequence.** Every choice shows its pencil marks before it is made, in words and arrows, never in percentages the player cannot act on. Fog of war stays: the preview says what the road agent can see, and nothing more.

From working systems to addictive loops

A system works when it produces correct numbers. It is addictive when it produces a question the player wants to answer next week.

System	Works today by	Becomes a loop when it
Living storylines	Tracking heat and freshness per feud	Shows the ending window opening and closing, so the player times the payoff like a wonder race.
Relationship memory	Remembering every answer	Brings a remembered slight back at the worst moment: the star refused a title shot walks out during the flagship.
The road and markets	Scaling each city's draw	Makes a cold city a goal: win it back three times and it becomes a home market with its own chant.

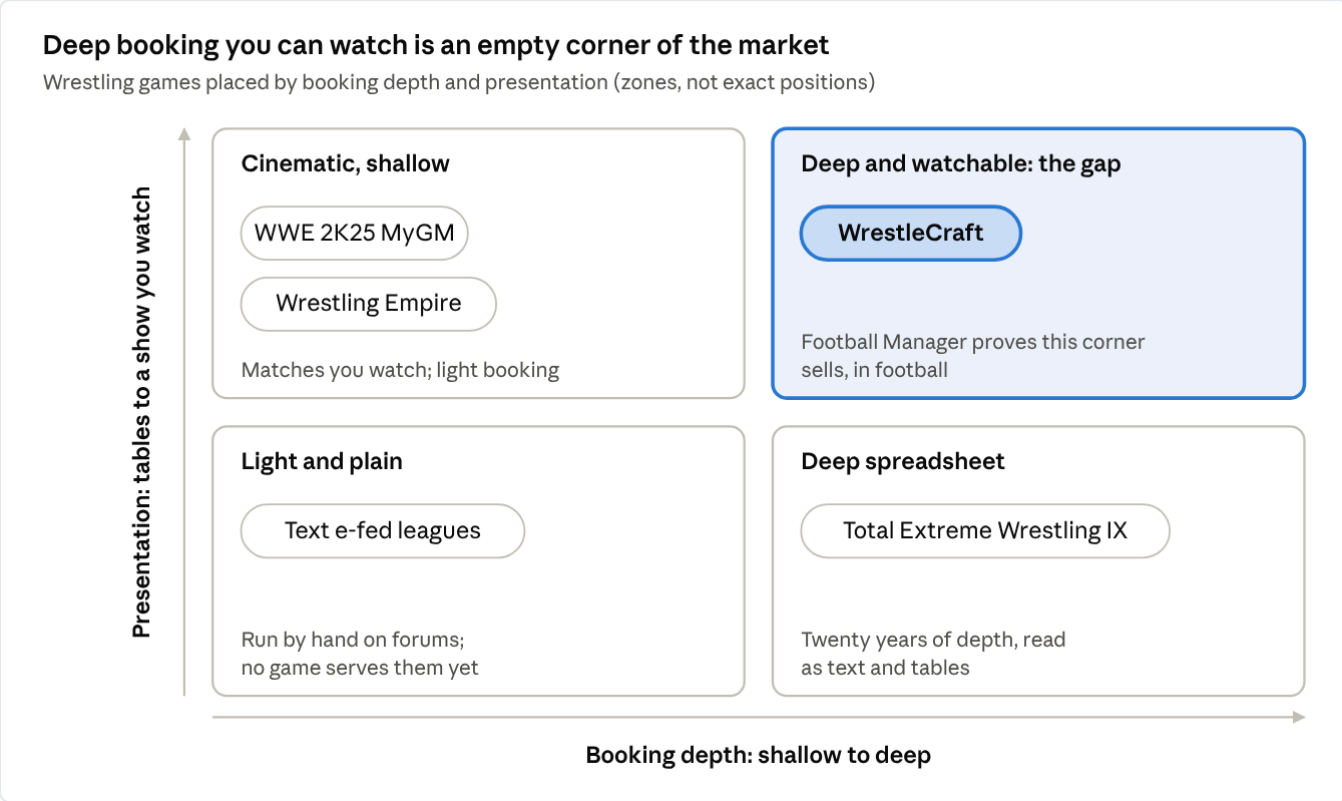
System	Works today by	Becomes a loop when it
Progression	Levels, points and perks	Turns a level-up into a booking problem: the student now outdraws the champion who trained them.
Networks	Patience, taste and targets	Puts a renewal on a countdown the whole season builds toward.
The press	Leaks and columns	Lets the player feed or starve a reporter, so tomorrow's headline is a lever, not weather.

Built to last

A game perfected over years should also be played for years. Four long-game commitments: careers that span decades (stars age, retire, become staff, come back); a world that keeps its own history (every reign, moment and grade, already kept by `src/84-kept.js` and the archive); a creator suite strong enough to feed a modding scene; and multiplayer leagues that give players a reason to come back every week. Each is a candidate for the gates, built only once the spine and the feel are right.

3. Competitive landscape and cross-genre analysis

The market has a hole exactly where WrestleCraft stands: deep booking with a show you watch. On a long timeline the field will move, so the plan should invest in the advantages that compound over years rather than in features a rival can copy in one release.



Market map: four zones, booking depth by presentation

The top-right corner has no wrestling game in it; Football Manager shows that corner sells in another sport.

The direct field

Competitor	What it does best	Where it leaves a gap
Total Extreme Wrestling IX (Grey Dog, August 2024)	The deepest booking sim for twenty years, with large community databases	Text and tables. No show you watch, and a learning curve measured in weeks.
WWE 2K25 MyGM (publisher notes)	Licensed stars, full 3D matches, and up to four players booking at the same time online	Shallow economy and story; no custom rosters online; matches are simulated online, not watched.
Wrestling Empire and similar arcade sims	Instant fun from a wrestler's point of view	Booking is a side mode with no lasting world.
Football Manager	The standard for depth with a watchable match engine	Proves the market for deep sims with a picture; does not touch wrestling.
Crusader Kings III	People as the system: memory, schemes, succession	Shows how far relationship drama can carry a strategy game.

Where the genres clash or combine

Neighbouring genre	Synergy	Clash to manage
RPG (progression, perks, traits)	Levels and perks make stars feel grown, not bought.	The player is the booker, not the wrestler: progression must create booking problems, never a grind.
Simulation	"Odds, not orders" keeps results surprising and the world alive.	Too much simulation hides cause and effect; every swing names its reason after the bell.
Tactics (the gorilla position)	Live calls give the show a hands-on layer no rival has.	Call spam: calls must be rare, caused by the night, and capped by the Director.
Narrative choice games	Matters on the desk read like a story with consequences.	Choices that feel like menus: each needs a face, a still picture and a memory.
Creator sandboxes	Create a Wrestler and the World Editor can feed a modding scene like TEW's databases.	Creator scope can swallow the game; the editor serves play.

Advantages that compound over years

1. **The e-fed league.** Online text e-federations (Ryan's own WrestlePower is one) have run for decades with no game built for them. An asynchronous league, one company per human and one booked week per real day, is a market of one, and a community grows with every season it runs.
2. **The watchable booking sim.** TEW players want to see their show; 2K players want their booking to matter. A papercraft broadcast with real consequences sits between them.
3. **The modding long tail.** A world package with wrestlers, scenes, belts, rules and promos made in-game can keep the game alive for years, as TEW's databases do. Every year of polish on the creator suite pays back for the whole life of the game.
4. **The streamer's show.** A live broadcast with calls, a feed and a crowd meter is built for streaming; chat as the crowd turns a stream into part of the show.
5. **Handmade as brand.** In a market of photoreal licensed games and plain tables, a papercraft look is recognisable at a glance, and it does not age the way realism does.

4. Inspirational deep dive: Civilization VI and Stellaris

Take Civilization VI's visible next goals and Stellaris's world that changes without you; leave behind Civ's late-game slog and Stellaris's mid-game micromanagement. Both games are at their best when the player can see a reward approaching and the world surprises them on the way.

What makes Civilization VI's "one more turn" work

- **Overlapping countdowns.** A building, a tech, a wonder and a border are each a few turns from done. The player never reaches a turn where nothing is about to happen.
- **Eurekas and Inspirations.** Doing something in the world cuts a research cost in half. The game rewards play, not waiting, and tells you what you are halfway to.
- **District adjacency.** Placing a district is a small spatial puzzle with a visible preview of every bonus before you commit, and the commitment lasts the whole game.
- **Historic Moments and eras.** In Rise and Fall, notable firsts earn Era Score; at each era change a high score brings a Golden Age, a low one a Dark Age, and a Dark Age turned around becomes a Heroic Age. A Dedication chosen each era adds more points, and the Timeline turns play into a history book.
- **Slow shared pressure.** In Gathering Storm, emissions drive climate change: rising seas, floods, storms and droughts that players soften with dams and sea barriers, beside a returning World Congress where votes are bought with Favor.

Civ VI's pitfalls to avoid: the late-game slog once the winner is clear; AI that cannot use its own systems; information hidden behind lenses and sub-menus; end-of-turn notification spam; long turn processing in multiplayer.

What makes Stellaris's scope and storytelling work

- **Anomalies and event chains.** Exploration turns up small mysteries that unfold into multi-step stories with real rewards and risks.
- **Ethics and factions.** Every population holds beliefs; factions form, make demands and change approval, so internal politics push back on the player.
- **Sleeping giants.** Fallen Empires sit dormant and powerful, and awaken when the galaxy crosses a line.
- **Crises with a shape.** A mid-game threat and an end-game crisis give a long campaign acts; a galactic community votes on shared rules.
- **Origins.** A starting story that changes how a whole campaign plays.

Stellaris's pitfalls to avoid: players describe a mid-game dead zone after the first crisis, with "nothing left to do" but wait for the end; planet micromanagement and event spam; and late-game slowdown serious enough that the 4.0 update made pops act in groups of 100 to cut the calculations.

Blended mechanics for WrestleCraft

Each concept borrows a proven hook, lands in an existing system, and is said in words on one screen. All are candidates for the three gates, not decisions.

Concept	From Civ VI	From Stellaris	In WrestleCraft	What the player sees
Eras of Wrestling	Era Score, Golden and Dark Ages, Dedications	Crises that give a campaign acts	Moments on the air (a first title, an upset, a five-star match, a sell-out) earn era score; at the flagship the year is judged a Boom, a Slump or a Comeback. Each era the booker picks a dedication (Workrate, Spectacle, Story, Violence) that counts its moments double.	A Timeline page of stills and a verdict ceremony at the flagship.
The Promoters' Summit	World Congress	Galactic Community	Once a year every company votes on industry rules: a talent-sharing ban, a pay-per-view price floor, a concussion protocol. Votes cost favour and bind everyone.	One pop-up a year: three resolutions, your vote, the result.
Card adjacency preview	District adjacency preview	none	The running-order rules (`src/92-shape.js`) shown before placing: pencil arrows on neighbouring segments.	Arrows and short words on the run sheet while dragging.
Booking Eurekas	Eurekas and Inspirations	none	Halfway marks on stories and stars: "two more wins on television and the crowd will buy her as a contender".	A thin progress line on the wrestler and the feud.
Scouting anomalies	none	Anomalies and event chains	Scouting the indies reveals mysteries: a gem with a bad reputation, a masked star nobody can place.	A scouting report card that opens the next step.
Locker-room ethics	none	Ethics and factions	Backstage Politics (`TASKS.md` 0ak) on two axes: Workrate against Spectacle, Loyalty against Money. Factions form and make demands.	Faction cards with a leader, a mood and one demand.
The Sleeping Giant	none	Fallen Empires	The Hall of Flame legends company stays quiet until the industry disrespects its history, then wakes and raids rosters.	A dirt sheet warning, then a rival that suddenly matters.
Industry wear	Climate change	none	Every company's hardcore matches and overwork feed one shared meter; as it rises, injuries rise everywhere and the Summit debates protocols.	One meter in words on the desk.

Keeping spreadsheet fatigue out

- **Ask, do not show.** The desk raises one decision at a time; numbers live behind "why?".
- **Words over numbers.** Markets, standing and heat are already said in words; every new system follows.
- **Automate with a personality.** The assistant handles the tedious part and says what it did in one line.
- **Group to scale.** Like Stellaris 4.0's pop groups, treat the mid-card as groups (a division, a stable) so the late game stays fast and readable.

5. Tech and systems critique: the engine, killer animations and multiplayer

Keep the web platform and rebuild the engine in TypeScript; make every impact land with weight; build multiplayer on the deterministic engine, the asynchronous league first. With freedom to switch anything, the deciding question is which stack lets Opus 5.5 build, run, test and look at its own work without a person in the loop.

The engine decision: switch the language, not the engine

The web stack lets the agent do everything itself in the cloud today: 94 test suites run headless in Chromium with no GPU and no editor, and Playwright takes screenshots to check how pages look. An engine that needs its editor open on a desktop cuts the agent off from its own work and makes Ryan the bottleneck for every build.

Option	Fit for building with Opus 5.5	Fit for this game	Cost to switch	Verdict
Stay on the web stack (Electron, Preact, three.js) and rebuild the engine in TypeScript modules	Best: everything runs and is tested in the cloud sandbox; TypeScript is the language the agent writes most reliably	A menu-heavy management sim with a 2.5D diorama is what the web stack does well	About 1 to 2 months, protected by golden-master tests	**Recommended**
Godot 4	Good: runs headless on Linux; scripts and scenes are text the agent can edit	A strong renderer, but dozens of dense pages rebuilt in its UI nodes	About 4 to 6 months; the 42 browser suites are lost	Only if the diorama outgrows WebGL
Unity 6	Fair: a Claude plugin drives a running Unity Editor, but the editor and its licence live on Ryan's PC	The best 3D tools and the widest console reach	6 months or more; the agent loses its cloud autonomy	No
Unreal 5, or Bevy in Rust	Weak: a heavy editor, or a young UI toolkit	Far more engine than a booking sim needs	The highest	No

What the rebuild means:

- **Typed modules and one command layer.** The simulation leaves the single shared ES5 closure (105 files, about 1.6 MB) for TypeScript modules with a typed `S`, and every change to the state becomes a named `E.*` command. Multiplayer, replays and bug reports all need exactly this.
- **Golden masters first.** Record a dozen seeds' full 100-week states before touching anything, then refactor until every seed matches byte for byte. This is what makes a large AI refactor safe.
- **Files, not one page.** The desktop build loads its files as needed instead of one 8.4 MB page; the artifact page becomes a secondary export for playtests.
- **The renderer stays three.js** (0.169 today, already with depth of field) and gains a WebGPU path. Electron stays, because steamworks.js already runs in it.

Animation blueprint

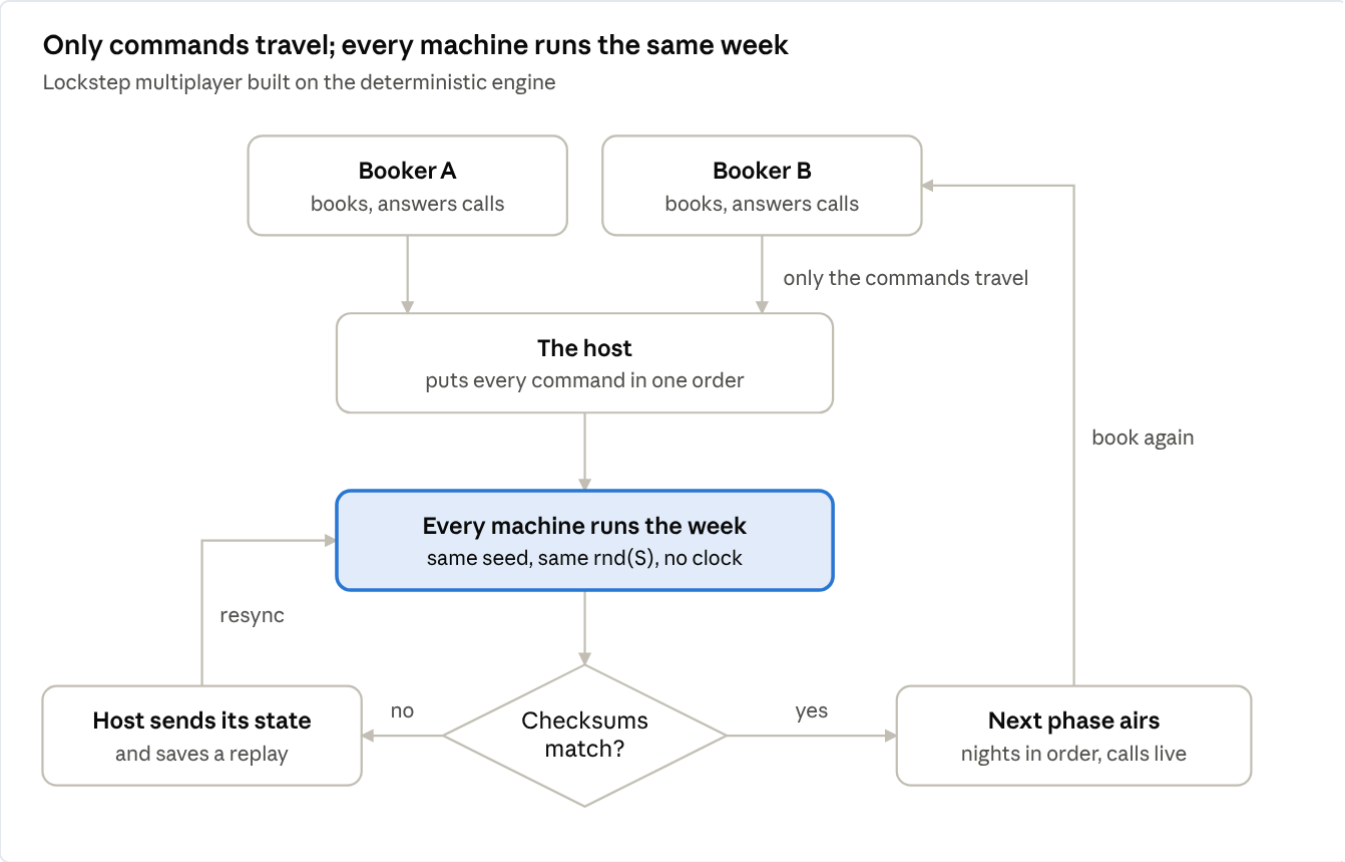
The diorama renderer (`app/src/kit/paper.ts`, `puppet.ts`, `scene.ts`, `diorama3d.ts`) is the game's graphics engine. Every move is procedural and shared, so 500 wrestlers need no hand-made animation each. Its weakness today is that motion is smooth but weightless. Five rules fix that.

1. **Stop-motion cadence, smooth camera.** Pose the figures on twos (12 poses a second) while the camera, lights and particles run at 60 frames a second, the way handmade stop-motion reads as craft rather than as a low frame rate.
2. **Anticipation, impact, hit-stop, recovery.** A wind-up pose; a contact frame held for a beat (about 2 frames for a jab up to 6 for a powerbomb, scaled by `poundsOf()`); a flex of the card that springs back; then the recovery. Sound and camera land on the held frame.
3. **A television director for the camera.** Wide on the lock-up, tight on the near fall, a crowd cutaway after the kick-out, a slow push on the finisher, driven by the beat flags `callMatch()` already sets. The referee clipping is fixed in the same pass.
4. **Scale is density.** A hall show has a few dozen card cut-outs and one light; the flagship has thousands of instanced cut-outs, a lighting rig, pyro and a crane shot.
5. **Choreography with structure.** Feeling-out, the heat, the hope spot, the comeback, false finishes, the finish. A protected finisher kicked out of gets a bigger camera move, so a rare kick-out feels rare.

Interface motion follows the same physics: windows land with a slight rotation and settle, the grade arrives as a rubber stamp, bad news tears, money counts up like an odometer. Every motion lasts 120 to 250 ms and never blocks input. **Performance budget:** 16.6 ms a frame at 1080p on a modest PC, instanced crowds, card textures baked once, the simulation off the main thread, and a quality setting that drops depth of field and soft shadows first.

Multiplayer evaluation

Viability: high, because the engine is already deterministic. The state `S` is plain JSON, every random draw comes from the seeded `rnd(S)`, and `test-determinism.js` checks that the same seed gives the same game. That allows lockstep, the model strategy games prefer: send each player's commands, not the world, and let every machine run the same simulation.



Lockstep week: commands in, checksums out

Concern	Approach
Desync prevention	A lint bans `Math.random`, the clock and unordered iteration in the engine; one pinned Electron (V8) version for multiplayer; a checksum of `S` after every phase.
Desync recovery	On a mismatch the host sends its state (about 1.5 MB at week 150, much smaller compressed) and play resumes; the command log goes with the bug report.
Simultaneous turns	The week is naturally simultaneous: everyone works the Office and books at once, then the nights air in order, and head-to-head nights resolve together as `src/88-nights.js` already does.
Calls on the air	Each booker's own show is live only for them; their calls are commands like any other; a turn timer and the assistant's safe answer cover anyone who walks away.
Engagement while waiting	Watch a rival's broadcast live, react on the feed, play the podcast's pick'em, and counter-program (a surprise on opposite them).
Matchmaking	Friends lobbies through Steam (steamworks.js is already wired) and a browser of public leagues; ranked play does not suit the genre.
Networking	Steam peer-to-peer with the host ordering commands for live play; a small relay that stores commands for asynchronous leagues.

Three modes, cheapest first: the asynchronous e-fed league (up to a dozen bookers, one week per real day, no live netcode); Monday Night War (2 to 4 players live, shared free agency by sealed bids, head-to-head nights on the air); and the front office co-op (an owner and a booker running one company together).

6. Polish, depth and thematic integration

Wrestling's real themes are the line between the work and the shoot, the body as the currency, loyalty against money, art against commerce, and legacy. The deepest ideas make those themes into choices; the best polish makes every press feel handmade and deliberate. The depth ideas are systems and go through the gates; the polish ideas are exempt and can be built whenever the feel phase arrives.

Five depth ideas

1. **The lie stack (kayfabe as risk).** Every work the booker sets up (a fake injury, a staged walk-out, a worked shoot on the microphone) has a list of who knows. Each person in on it is a leak risk shaped by their relationship with you and with the press (`src/99-kayfabe.js`, `src/99-press.js`). The bigger the lie, the bigger the payoff and the harder the fall: an exposed work costs trust with the crowd, the network and the locker room at once.
2. **The body bank.** Every wrestler carries a finite career of bumps. Hardcore matches, ladder falls and stiff opponents draw on it; rest and the trainer slow the spend; it never refills. The file shows it as seasons left, in words. Spend a beloved veteran's last bumps on the flagship, or protect him and lose the moment. Retirement matches become planned nights with their own ceremony.
3. **Art against commerce.** Every card nudges the company's identity along two visible axes: workrate against spectacle, story against shock. Networks, sponsors and the owner pull toward commerce; the locker room's factions and the hardcore fans pull toward art. Drift changes who wants to sign, which network will carry you, and which wrestlers grow.
4. **The torch.** Every era needs its next top star, and the stars at the top know it. Making a new main-eventer counts as a historic moment; burying one is remembered by the whole locker room. A champion can pass the torch willingly, demand a price, or refuse and sabotage.
5. **The booker's own career.** The booker is a person in the world: reputation across the industry, stress and a contract. A brilliant season draws offers from rivals; a run of flops ends with the owner's call. Being fired and hired by a rival keeps the save going with a new company and an old grudge, and your exit becomes the next booker's mess.

Five polish ideas

1. **The stamp.** The show's grade lands as a rubber stamp: a short anticipation, a heavy thunk, ink that bleeds a little, the angle a touch off straight. An A is crisp; an F smudges. It is the most-seen moment in the game and should be the most satisfying.
2. **Pencil marks before ink.** While a segment is dragged on the run sheet, faint pencil arrows appear on its neighbours and on the wrestler ("cools the crowd", "tired", "hot follow-up"), and a soft murmur rises when a pairing the crowd wants is placed. On drop, pencil turns to marker.
3. **Paper that behaves like paper.** Pop-ups land with a 2 to 4 degree rotation and settle; their shadow grows as they lift and shrinks as they land; dismissed cards slide off rather than vanish; bad news has a torn edge.
4. **The morning paper.** The end of the week is a newspaper dropped on the desk with a thud: one headline from the Director, the photo of the week's moment, three short columns. An object the player wants to read and screenshot, instead of a summary screen.

5. **Hands-on quality of life.** Undo any booking change until the bell; compare two wrestlers side by side; search that finds any person, title or city from anywhere; pad rumble on a slam and on the stamp; every page restores its last selection.

7. Fifty new ideas

Fifty ideas the game does not have yet, checked against the code and the queue, in five groups of ten. "System" ideas need the three gates before any code; "Polish" is exempt under rule 9d; "Tool" ideas are for building the game, not playing it, and are the cheapest to start because they make every later step safer.

The booking and the show

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
1	Dark matches	A bout before the broadcast tests a pairing or warms the crowd, revealing chemistry through the fog without risking television.	System
2	The audible	A hand signal from the gorilla changes a finish mid-match; the workers might miss it, and a botched audible is remembered.	System
3	Card templates	Save a run sheet's shape (the go-home show, the open-challenge night) and reuse it; the assistant fills the names.	Polish
4	Time-limit drama	Book a match to a time-limit draw; the clock shows on the chyron and the crowd counts down the last minute.	System
5	Rematch clauses	A title loss can carry a contractual rematch that sets next month's main event and pressures the card.	System
6	Crowd signs	Hand-lettered signs in the diorama crowd react to storylines and read as a gauge of what fans want.	Polish
7	The cold open	A show can open on a recap package of a feud; its quality depends on the production staff.	System
8	Surprise returns	A hidden slot on the run sheet for a returning star; secrecy sets the pop, and a leak kills it.	System
9	Themed nights	A tribute show, a hometown night or an open-challenge night changes what the crowd expects and offers moments of its own.	System
10	Commentary assignments	Choose which announcers call which match; a great caller lifts a mid-card bout, a bored one flattens it.	System

People and the locker room

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
11	Medical clearance calls	The doctor gives a recovery window; clearing a star early for a big night is an attempt, and a re-injury is remembered by everyone.	System
12	Wrestler diaries	Stars who trust you let you read a short weekly journal that shows their wants and grievances before they become demands.	System
13	Agents at the table	Some stars negotiate through an agent with a personality and a history with you; win the agent and you win their whole stable of clients.	System
14	Celebrity guests	Hire a celebrity for a big night: a pop and mainstream press, but the locker room resents the spot and a botch is mocked for years.	System

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
15	Wellness policy	Strict testing pleases networks and sponsors; a lax one keeps some stars happy; a failed test is a matter with no good answer.	System
16	Gimmick pitches	Wrestlers pitch their own character changes; saying yes builds trust and can make a hit or a flop.	System
17	Stiff workers	A known stiff worker hurts opponents more and the room avoids them, but the crowd believes every match they have.	System
18	Friends at rival companies	Wrestlers keep friends elsewhere, which carries rumours, poaching tips and ways back.	System
19	The road crew	Ring crew, wardrobe and travel staff with their own morale; a burnt-out crew causes mistakes on the air.	System
20	Exit interviews	When someone leaves, a last talk records why; the reasons feed the dirt sheet and every future negotiation with them.	System

The world, the business and the long game

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
21	Merchandise design	Design shirts with the creator tools; sales depend on the design and on who wears it on television.	System
22	Tape library deals	Sell old shows to a classic channel; the library becomes an asset and a nostalgia market.	System
23	Regional syndication	Sell a weekly highlight show to local stations in toured markets: small money that keeps cities warm between visits.	System
24	Tours abroad	A tour overseas with jet lag, crowds that love different styles, and a working agreement with a local company.	System
25	Talent exchanges	Lend and borrow wrestlers with partner companies; both sides keep the relationship and the risk.	System
26	Your own building	Buy an arena: a home crowd with its own culture, cheaper nights, and a mortgage.	System
27	Industry cycles	Booms and busts across years (a television money boom, a recession) that no company controls.	System
28	Rival bookers as people	Each rival company's booker has a name, a style and a memory of you; they copy your hits and target your stars.	System
29	The documentary	Once a year a film crew follows the company; what they catch, good or bad, airs and moves popularity and morale.	System
30	Retired stars run indies	Retirees open small promotions that remember how you treated them: a farm system or a thorn.	System

Presentation, feel and the creator suite

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
31	Photo mode	Pause any moment on the broadcast, frame it, caption it and save it to the Timeline or a poster.	Polish

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
32	Automatic event posters	Every big event gets a poster made from its card in the paper style, editable in Create a Scene.	Polish
33	The year's highlight reel	At year's end, the season's top moments cut together with the soundtrack.	Polish
34	Seasons on the diorama	Snow outside the arena in winter, summer stadium shows at dusk; the weather the simulation already tracks, made visible.	Polish
35	Entrance motifs	Each star's entrance gets a short musical motif in the soundtrack's palette that the crowd learns.	Polish
36	Front-row regulars	Recurring superfans in the front row appear in pictures, react to turns, and can be lost.	Polish
37	Paper damage	Figures crease and scuff through a brutal match and are mended between weeks: the body bank made visible.	Polish
38	Running jokes on commentary	Callers build catchphrases and running jokes over a season from the grammar.	Polish
39	Accessibility suite	Colour-blind palettes, a plain-font option beside the hand lettering, caption speed, and full screen-reader labels.	Polish
40	A living title screen	The title screen shows the last save's champion in their arena as a diorama.	Polish

Building it: tools, workflow and community

#	Idea	What it does	Kind
41	The balance dashboard	Nightly headless seasons logged as data and charted on a private dashboard, so balance is seen, not guessed.	Tool
42	The golden-master guard	Every pull request replays a dozen seeds and flags any change in outcome, with a list of what moved.	Tool
43	AI playtesters	Scripted personas (the min-maxer, the storyteller, the newcomer) play 50 weeks through Playwright and report where they stalled and what they never used.	Tool
44	The question bank	Every protocol question and answer kept as data, so new blueprints cite past decisions and never re-ask them.	Tool
45	Screenshot diffs	Every page photographed at 1080p, 1440p and 4K on each pull request and compared with the last approved look.	Tool
46	A save-file corpus	A library of real saves from many weeks and versions that every build must load, guarding rule 9 automatically.	Tool
47	A hidden developer console	Jump to a week, raise a call, force a matter: for Ryan's playtests and for reproducing bugs.	Tool
48	One-file bug reports	A report bundles the seed, the command log and a screenshot, so Opus 5.5 can replay the bug exactly.	Tool
49	The design bible	One living document per pillar (look, sound, words, numbers) that the review step checks every change against.	Tool
50	A mod kit, early	The world format, an example mod and a Workshop plan, published before the reveal so modders are ready on day one.	Tool

8. Viability and the long-term plan

The game is viable as a long-term, one-person project built with Opus 5.5, and time is an asset: rebuild the foundation now, while the game is still small enough to change, and perfect it before anyone sees it. The bottleneck is not code (Opus 5.5 produced 595 commits in 17 days); it is Ryan's decisions, play time and taste. The plan protects those hours, keeps the web platform but rebuilds the engine in TypeScript, changes three rules and adds four, and moves every new system through the protocol's three gates.

Stress test

Measure	Today	Reading
Pace	595 commits in 17 days	Opus 5.5 builds faster than one person can decide and play; the pace is set by Ryan, not the code.
Size	About 1.6 MB of simulation in 105 files; about 1.5 MB of interface in 112 files	Large for one shared ES5 scope with dense lines: the agent spends context on every change, and distant breakage is likely.
Tests	52 headless and 42 browser suites, a determinism check	The project's greatest asset, and what makes unattended AI work safe.
CI	GitHub Actions builds, type-checks and runs a 20-week sim on every push	Runs a small part of the suite; the rest runs only when a session remembers to.
Open queue	231 open boxes in `TASKS.md` against 234 done	Half the plan is ahead, mostly new systems without a go-ahead.
Simulation cost	11 companies, 497 wrestlers: about 60 ms per simulated week	Rival AI scaling is not a problem yet.
Steam	Electron, steamworks.js, 62 achievements; never run on the Steam client	Needs a real PC; the cloud sandbox cannot run Steam.

How it gets built: one person and Opus 5.5

Ryan directs; Opus 5.5 is the studio. Ryan decides, plays, judges feel and approves the gates. Opus 5.5 writes the blueprints and question vaults, the code and tests, makes and auditions the assets, and keeps the docs true. The tooling's job is to make Ryan's hours count: every decision reaches him as one clear question, every result as something to play or hear.

Job	Tool	How it is used
Building	Claude Code on the web, desktop and command line, running Opus 5.5	One branch and pull request per step; `CLAUDE.md`, `TASKS.md` and `NEXT.md` carry the memory between sessions.
Unattended runs	Scheduled tasks in Claude Code	Overnight runs work an approved `NEXT.md`; a nightly run plays every test and a 100-week balance sweep and writes the results into a doc.
Safety net	GitHub Actions, pull-request watching, Claude Code Review	CI grows to every headless test and the Playwright suites; Claude watches its own pull requests and fixes red CI; a review bot reads every diff.

Job	Tool	How it is used
Second opinions	Subagents and multi-agent workflows	Explore and Plan agents for research and architecture; a workflow for large audits when Ryan asks for one.
The protocol	Claude Docs and one-at-a-time question prompts	Blueprints and vaults as docs Ryan can comment on; questions asked one at a time; approvals recorded in `TASKS.md` with the date.
Taste decisions	Artifact audition pages with saved picks	The pattern that chose every sound: candidates on a page, Keep or Reject, picks read back. Next for art, motion, belts and logos.
Plugins and skills	engineering (code-review, debug, testing-strategy, tech-debt, architecture), design (design-critique, accessibility-review, ux-copy, research-synthesis), simplify, security-review	An architecture record for each big change, a design critique for each new page, playtest notes synthesised.
A project toolkit	Project skills and hooks in `.claude/` (none yet), and a Claude mod built with plugin-authoring	Skills for `/blueprint`, `/vault`, `/audition`, `/publish-live` and `/balance`; a hook that blocks a commit when headless tests fail; a side panel showing each system's gate status.
Real hardware	Remote Control and computer use on Ryan's PC	Steam client tests, frame timing on a low-end GPU, gamepad checks: what the cloud sandbox cannot do.
Assets	Blender (bpy) headless, three.js, Piper, ffmpeg, Playwright screenshots	Procedural art and sound made and checked in the sandbox; screenshots compared to catch visual regressions.

Rules to change

Rule today	Change to	Why
9a: one step at a time, shown to Ryan, then wait	Approved plans run unattended in long runs; Ryan reviews at milestones and whenever a gate needs him	Waiting after every step spends Ryan's time on work he already approved; rule 9d still guards anything new.
Publish every change to the live page	Publish a nightly build and a named milestone build	The live page is a private playtest copy, not the product.
One self-contained page shapes the build	The desktop build comes first; the page is an export	Rule 0 already says Steam is the product.
New	Tests are the gate: nothing merges unless every headless test passes; browser suites run nightly	Unattended AI work is only safe behind a full wall of tests.
New	A system budget: each new system names its Director tag, what it hands the next phase, and what it replaces	Keeps sprawl from returning once the Director lands.
New	The hour of play: Ryan plays a full session at every milestone, and his notes become the next plan	Feel and fun cannot be tested headless.
New	`CLAUDE.md` becomes a short core with linked area notes; recurring procedures become skills	Every session starts cold; a shorter core leaves room for the work.

Rule today	Change to	Why
Default world: the parody world	Decided (Ryan, 23 October): an original world leads, and the parody world becomes optional	It lowers the legal risk of showing the game, and the store page shows the game's own characters.

Bottlenecks

1. **Ryan's time.** Every gate, audition and playtest needs him, and at Opus 5.5's pace the queue of decisions grows faster than one person can answer. Batch the questions into sessions and keep a weekly decision hour.
2. **Sprawl.** More than 40 systems compete for the desk and the queue adds twelve more. The Director, the system budget and the gates are the fix.
3. **The single scope.** The shared ES5 closure costs context on every change and hides distant breakage; the TypeScript rebuild removes it.
4. **Memory between sessions.** Each session starts cold and `CLAUDE.md` is already very long. A short core, area notes, a generated `docs/map.md` and skills keep the agent fast and correct.
5. **What the cloud cannot test.** Steam, real GPUs, gamepads and sound on real speakers need Ryan's PC, through Remote Control, computer use, or Ryan himself.
6. **Taste.** Feel, art and sound cannot be judged headless; every taste question goes to an audition page, never to a guess.
7. **Rival AI depth.** Rivals do not keep feuds yet (`rivalRipe()` is ready). Worth more than any new player-side system, and needed for multiplayer.
8. **Content and legal.** An original world now leads (Ryan, 23 October), so it needs the depth, looks and history the parody world has today; whether the parody world ships as an optional pack is still open. Boos still need a recording source; Freesound is blocked from the sandbox until Ryan allows it in the environment's network settings.

The protocol in the plan

The three gates run as a pipeline beside the build: while one phase is built, Opus 5.5 writes the next phase's blueprints and vaults, and Ryan answers and approves them, so the build never waits and never runs ahead of a decision. Small fixes, polish and tools are exempt; a new mode, system or major feature never is; when in doubt, Ryan is asked.

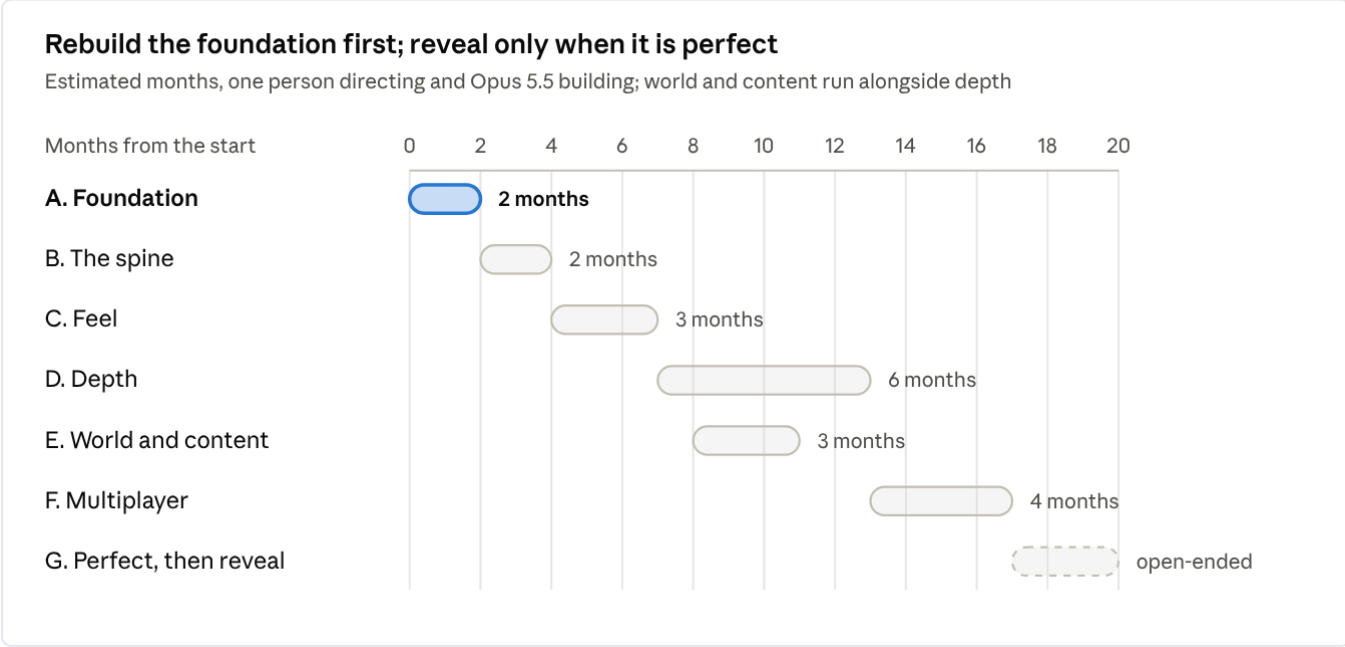
1. **Blueprint.** One standalone file, `docs/plans/<feature>.md`: the states and what moves them, the data it keeps on `S`, the screen flow, the money and balance loop, and what it hands the next phase.
2. **Question vault.** Categorised questions on edge cases, how a player will think and feel, what brings them back for one more turn, and the odd situations it must survive. Asked one at a time; answers written into the blueprint.
3. **Approval.** Ryan's plain go-ahead, recorded in `TASKS.md` with the date. No source files before it.

Candidate	Blueprint	Question vault	Go-ahead	Next step
The Director (`TASKS.md` 0aa)	`docs/plans/director.md`	3 open questions, unanswered	Added to the plan before the protocol	A full vault, then approval
Backstage Politics, the last booker's mess, traits and perks, pre-history, come back changed, company arcs (0ab to 0al)	Written	2 or 3 open questions each, unanswered	Added before the protocol	A full vault, then approval
The magazine, the hallway, word travels, buildings that remember, the locker room as a place	Written	Not started	Added before the protocol	A vault, then approval
Blended mechanics (section 4), depth ideas (section 6), system ideas 1 to 30 (section 7)	None	None	None	Blueprint, when its phase comes
Multiplayer: league, live, co-op	None	None	None	One blueprint per mode, the league first
Polish ideas (sections 6 and 7) and tool ideas 41 to 50	Not needed	Not needed	Exempt	Build in their phase

A starter vault for the Director, the first system on the critical path, folding in the three questions already in its blueprint:

Topic	Question
Edge cases	In a week with nothing urgent, does the Director invent a fire or let the week be quiet?
Edge cases	When two hard matters fall due the same week, which waits, and does waiting cost anything?
Player psychology	Should the player see the Director at all (a word on the desk), or only feel it?
Player psychology	Will a player who loves to manage everything feel robbed when the cap holds matters back?
One more turn	Must every show end on a hook, or can a great night end clean as a reward?
One more turn	How often should a chance (good news) come instead of a problem?
Balance	Is the Director's style a difficulty setting, and can it change mid-game?
Scope	Three styles to start, or The Promoter first and the others after it plays well?
Odd situations	What does it do in a save from before it existed, and does each multiplayer booker get their own?

The long-term plan



Long-term plan: seven phases, estimated months

Phase	Estimate	Work	Tools	Protocol	Gate to leave it
A. Foundation	About 2 months	Golden masters; the engine in TypeScript modules with one command layer; the full suite in CI; tool ideas 41 to 48; project skills and hooks; `CLAUDE.md` split into a core and area notes.	Claude Code, GitHub Actions, the engineering plugin's architecture records, a review workflow on request	Tools and refactoring are exempt; Ryan approves the architecture record	Every golden-master seed matches byte for byte; CI runs every headless test.
B. The spine	About 2 months	The Director, the interruption cap, the promise ledger, one headline a week; rivals that keep feuds.	Claude Docs for blueprints and vaults; nightly balance runs	The Director and the promise ledger pass all three gates first	Ryan plays a full season and meets one headline a week.
C. Feel	About 3 months	Stop-motion cadence, hit-stop and card flex, the camera director, paper motion, the stamp, boos, the frame budget and quality setting; polish ideas 31 to 40.	Audition pages, screenshot diffs, Remote Control on Ryan's PC for frame timing	Polish: exempt	60 frames a second on a low-end PC; every motion picked on an audition page.
D. Depth	About 6 months	Approved systems only, one at a time, from sections 4, 6 and 7.	Subagents for research, a design critique per page, AI playtesters	All three gates per system	Each system's hand-off and 60-week tests pass, and Ryan keeps it after a play session.

Phase	Estimate	Work	Tools	Protocol	Gate to leave it
E. World and content	About 3 months, alongside D	The original flagship world built out to the parody world's depth (rosters, looks, history, belts); the creator suite finished; the mod kit (idea 50).	Blender, Piper, the World Editor	Gates for any new creator tool	A new player can make and share a world without help.
F. Multiplayer	About 4 months	The asynchronous e-fed league, then Monday Night War, then co-op.	steamworks.js networking; Remote Control on two PCs	Each mode passes all three gates	A four-week league between four machines with no desync.
G. Perfect, then reveal	Open-ended	Private playtests with Steam playtest keys, notes synthesised, polish rounds; then the store page and trailer when Ryan says it is ready.	The design plugin's research synthesis; Canva for store art	Exempt	Ryan's call.

About a year and a half of building before the reveal phase, set by decisions and play time rather than code. The order matters more than the dates: a foundation the agent can change safely, a spine that paces the story, feel that makes every press satisfying, and only then more depth, a finished world and multiplayer. Nothing is shown until Ryan says it is perfect.

Sources

Game facts come from the WrestleCraft repository at version 0.88 (`CLAUDE.md`, `TASKS.md`, `NEXT.md`, `docs/design.md`, `docs/plans/`, `.github/workflows/ci.yml`, and the earlier review `docs/plans/EWF-game-review.pdf` of 17 October 2026) and from a 20-week headless run of every company in the parody world. The fifty ideas were checked against the code and the queue; ideas the game already has (a hall of fame, mentors, life events, the development camp) were left out. Phase lengths in section 8 are planning estimates, not measurements.

- Total Extreme Wrestling IX launch press release, Grey Dog Software, 14 August 2024
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